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Emigrant or Traveller? Misplaced or Evolved

The passing of time allows for the passing of arts through many stages that trace across the map. Does this migration instigate the synthesis of a novel burgeon? One that is infused with some of the primordial DNA, but marinated with a novel coat of worldly influences. Does it license us to strip culture of intrinsic personality? Or does it allow for advancement and expressivity, enabling abstraction and severance from suffocation obsolete paradigms? Through this research, I explore different concepts and branches of rhizomatic events in the mutations of dance and their footprints(repercussions), especially through the lens of Indian Traditional Dances. Raising the question of why artists today have a new sense of proxy to cross-experiment, I also delve into how contemporaneity occurs and the heat created around this movement of change.

Indian traditional dances are manifestations of an Indian body and spirit that arrives amidst a myriad of doctrines, religions, redolent beliefs, and century-old traditions. The country's heritage and religious timelines are fortified in this bodily expression. The Indian Dance cannot be one dimensional, it is embraced as Nāṭyaśāstra, which is the dialogue for the merging of scripture, dance, music, and drama. Indian Dance enforces our spiritual and mundane connections, stressing all aspects of life and telling the stories of the loves, triumphs, and exploitation of gods and kings; it also enforces the teaching of humanitarian values, the depiction of great wars between gods and humans, and the origination of traditions and cultures written down in our history. Indian Dance is understood as “the Cosmic Rhythm of the World", and as a

representation of the workings of the seven dvipas of Hinduism beliefs. Dance, Drama, and Music (Natya, Nritta, and Nrtya) work in a sort of tandem. It is a give-and-take relationship including various elements that contribute to the final literary piece and narrative: Stage presentation, graceful mime, intricate footwork, and choreography, hand and face gestures with articulate use of eyeballs, eyebrows, and eyes, extensive use of props and characters, emotions (rasa and bhava), and angular positions like 'aramandi' in Bharatanatyam. It consists of very expressive and established theatrical attires, dark and loud makeup, bindis, Ghungroos or other sound-making accessories, raven black hair tied in long plaits, and colorful and densely layered costumes with red Alta applied on hands to highlight mudras, and sun and moon accessories placed on the forehead. In Indian classical dance, taal is coordinated with Pada (feet) beats, to synchronize rhythm, and certain body parts like the neck and head are isolated with gentle sway in hips performed with utter grace. These values converge and result in a highly sensitized dancer with awareness of every body part (minor or major), to adroitly display the skills of Indian dance. Indian Dance refers to the human body movements as generic and not associated with a certain category of dancers or gender. Even the basic terminology of Indian dance is shared in all regions across India, regardless of the various different stylizations within. They are understood as a guide or an underlying methodology of corporeal movement and technique.

As explained above, Indian Classical Dancing is profoundly entrenched in the soul of the Indian nation and what it represents. That is what gives meaning and structure to its art and expression and to misplace it or detach it from its birthplace is an extreme decision resulting in many provocations. We wipe out this patrimony or rewrite it with poly-centric flavors for many reasons: to answer urgent questions of our times, to uptake social and global justice movements, to alienate from gender hierarchy; we also choose to cleave from conventional ideals that tell of

obstinate rules and sexism, patriarchal subjugation, from the male and their gaze, from specious and unfounded pious myths, or just for the sake of boredom and curiosity. One very important aspect to consider is the argument of the 'Hired body' by Susan Leigh Foster, in the book 'Reading Dance'. She contends that it makes a disgraceful artist who embodies diaspora dances that "emphasizes labor and its sexiness while selling itself." (Maska, 2011). Rather she encourages dancers to train in several existing techniques without adopting aesthetic visuals in it. For many artists, this proposes an impasse as the borderline between appreciation and appropriation is very slim, and thus contemporary or modern dance acts as a proxy for metamorphosis within different primitive dances. After all, we dance to synchronize and co-exist in current times; dance is sometimes described as the nonverbal and kinaesthetically incarnation of the rudimentary socio-political, economic, and temporal principles. "In order to enable a theorization of current work we want to imagine that it is part of some unifying trend, some consistent logic, or some aesthetic, political, cultural, or intellectual imperative that drives it. We aim to identify recognizable traits as a way to name something about the era in which we live. This aim reminds me that the term "contemporary" also connotes a temporal designation—it is the dance that is "together with time."."(Kwan, 2017). These efforts of expansion by artists bring currency to such urgent topics, making them somewhat ubiquitous. With the establishment of institutes like Paul Taylor, and Alvin Ailey that collectively display the width of modern dance textures imputed with individual inflections over long periods of time. In context to its assemblage of technique and the array of elements, it creates a practice of molding and remodeling the aesthetics of dance techniques with input from different creative vocabularies. This exclusivity cements the bricks of the "Composite body", or as the cultural theorist Randy Martin postulated, "one capable of encompassing a variety of political ideologies simultaneously,

and one that might reveal ‘How difference is associated among those assembled in the nation, rather than being forced to sort out one body from another.’” (Defrantz, 2005). After exposure to cohorts of varied repertoire became ubiquitous, it has become vital for performers, in today’s day and age, to train under multifaceted programs that are designed to expose us to diverse dance formats and vocabularies. This is essential if we want to make a fair living as a performer. Some could also argue that making ourselves befitting for the various company criteria and for a wider audience does not make us “Hired bodies” (with an incoherent mess of knowledge), but rather competent, professional, and experienced, within which a sense of niche and ethos can be developed. Keeping up with this diasporic and international element of the interdisciplinary style of education in arts is another pertinent reason for the inexorable fate of the diaspora. Such is seen in dance training and vocational programs all over the world.

The dispersion of such traditional styles also takes on a new meaning around different parts of the world, resulting in different layers of diversity within a single art form. Each choreographer adds Idiosyncrasy centralized around other Anthropocene influences. An example of postcolonial Intra-cultural hybrids in India is Neo-Bharatam, a style pioneered by a contemporary Indian dancer, Anita Ratnam. Her work deviates from traditional ‘margams’ and follows some course of the norm by depicting stories of gods like ‘Shiva’ or wearing a ‘saree’, plaiting hair adorned by ‘Chandra’ and ‘Surya’, putting ‘Tikka’ or ‘Bindi’ on the forehead, and tying ‘Ghungroos’ on the ankles. “Ratnam's performance that evening indeed transported her viewers from the world of the familiar here and now into a higher realm where the dancer becomes one with the music, and touches the spectators' hearts. Ratnam's is a highly accomplished and moving art of an ethno-global artist, one who is rooted in her indigenous Tamil culture, literature, and music, as well as one who has the imagination, intellect, and

creativity to reach into movement and musical traditions from a pan-Asian arena and beyond." (Katrak, 2008). Examples of intercultural hybrids are seen in choreographers like Akhram Khan, one of the biggest Indian names among hybrid choreographers around the world. He uses influences from his former Indian classical training and imbibes them with contemporary dance whilst intuitively creating and collaborating with artists such as Israel Galvan, Sylvie Guillem, the English National Ballet, etc. Such explorations have led to renowned renditions such as Jungle Book reimagined, Outwitting the Devil, DESH, Gnosis, and even his critically acclaimed version of 'Giselle'. Another example is performances like 'Dastak - I wish you me' by Anananya Dance Theatre. The artistic director of the company, Ananya Chatterjea, established this feminist contemporary dance company in the global art and social justice movement. She also has former childhood training in Indian classical dances as she spent her childhood in India, which she used as fuel to drive her choreography methods. Improvisation plays a vital role in the creation of Dastak. I personally attended the showing of this performance and from my vantage, the passion behind the message of this performance could not be expressed as intensely or beautifully without the dancers having creative freedom in their bodies. The dancers have dipped themselves in the sentiments of the people and stories they represent with heightened intensity. Their improvisation is set around a choreographic prompt or framework and is driven by picking up tremors of energy from the earth or the music. This score allows a lot of alterations within the peripheries of Indian classical dancing as each performer comes from a different culture and has previously been conditioned in eurocentric and other world dances. One of the very first influences of Indian classical dancing on foreign choreographers can be seen in Jack Cole and his creation of 'Kismet' (1955). He was known as the Father of Theatrical Jazz Dance with a bizarre and elusive collection of conducts - he transfused East Indian Bharata Natyam, modern,

ballet, Afro-Cuban, and African American dances, setting it to swing music. He also influenced choreographers like Bob Fosse, Jerome Robbins, Micheal Jackson, and Micheal Bennet. “ Jack Cole’s contributions were so far-reaching that without him present-day theatrical dancing would not be the same” (Vanity Fair, December 1984). In the video ‘kismet’, you can see the influence of Indian classical dancing in three costumes, the makeup, and the utilization of hand mudras, like ‘Tripataaka’, ‘Arthachnadra’, and ‘Mushthi’. It has also incorporated all the aspects of Indian classical dance: ‘Nritta’, ‘Nitya’, ‘Natya’, and used the coordination of rhythmic and syncopated percussive movements with the ‘Pada’. Positions like ‘Aramandi’ and ‘Shirobhedas’ can be distinctively seen throughout the choreography. Subconsciously and inadvertently, vestiges and roots of Indian dance might be present in the guise of Micheal Jackson’s performances, and in Fosse’s explorations and contributions to Jazz. The influence could also jump through time and be as far-reaching as Beyonce’s dance choreography in the music video ‘Single Ladies’, as it was inspired by Bob Fossse’s routine, ‘Mexican Breakfast’.

“Dirt, in anthropologist Mary Douglas’s famous formulation, is matter out of place (Douglas, 1966, p.40): matter is not intrinsically dirty, but only becomes so when it appears where it doesn’t ‘belong’.” (Roy, 1997). The question here is whether mutations in dance etiolate the primitive mould and cause an eruption of anarchy or does it foster freedom and a deeper recognition, purpose, and celebration of the arts. Some argue that the truth of the matter is that there is no scale of good vs. bad, it can only be validated by the individualistic perspective and independent approach in migrating dance. “Dirt is therefore an effect of a socially defined system of classification, a symbolic map of what belongs where.” (Roy, 1997). Contemporary is viewed as being owned by Euro-American dancers which undermine or invalidates the existence of Asian dances within its structure. “ “contemporary dance” is understood as an artistic genre; it is

the form dominated by Euro-American dance artists and perceived as merely “imitated” by non-Western dancers.” (Kwan, 2017). It is these western ideals that classify what fits into the symbolic map of Contemporary. Whilst it must seem almost natural for some artists around the world to diversify and embrace the ‘togetherness’ of the arts, many Eurocentric ideals are built on exclusivity and homogeneity. “Noise is an interference in the communication of information, a disturbance, or something that cannot be placed into a recognized pattern…Dirt and noise are, therefore, not things in themselves, but relative terms, disorders that are recognized only through a system of order, types of ‘otherness’.” (Roy, 1997). This feeling of otherness occurs inevitably because the movement and contemporaneity of this genesis, which has a culturally ornated genetic code, can accrue a lot of heat and friction. Friction causes alterity which can be inadvertent or advertent, chafing of the skin that swathes Indian classical dances that actuate deindividuation. “Most of these choreographers have reclaimed virtuosity and theatricality, but do not remain within the confinements of one pre-established movement aesthetic.” (Chatterjea, 2020). Thus a new conception of a quasi-experimental genre is often expressed as having contemporary dance suffused with ethnic lineage or vice versa, which challenges the politics of religionism, nationalism, and interculturalism. When many different outlooks and cultures are brought under the spotlight, a duality of opinions breeds a state of impasse or obscurity. Often, the mutations of dance have religious tentacles that till today, maneuver a great deal of its socio-political state. We tend to fixate only on the positive end of the spectrum, which we believe negates and sanitizes the opposite end of the duality, but there is a disguised and intangible network that we all get eventually caught up in. At the end of the day, change is the ultimate intention and purpose of our being. It is the only consistent concept in an ever-flowing cycle of the inconsistent.

The conclusion of this research is that change produces resistance and resistance produces heat. A set definition of what is good or bad, right or wrong can never be substantiated. This world exists in a state of non-dualism where we must ask ourselves what parameters shape the unfolding of a situation rather than questioning why the situation exists and how we superficially dominate change and establish a dysfunctional power paradigm. Asking certain questions can lead us to believe that we're lopping back and forth on a continuum and it's all a trap. I would like to close by irradiating how Ananya Chatterjea considers the concept of Heat. She has a very positive and productive outlook on a concept that can be heavily discussed on both extremes of the spectrum. She takes on 'Heat' in contemporary dance through a vantage of physics and biology, stating that the incessant cross between cultures and south-south artists brings ephemeral temperature changes in this dance form. This allows freedom of expression and effectuates ownership. Heat is a form of energy that opens pores and causes sweating, just as friction in contemporary dance opens doors to alterity. "With a commitment to transform the heat of anger into generative heat, emerging from centering alterity, I jump into the landscape of contemporary dance." (Chatterjea, 2020).

Citations

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